

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

(This is a two-page report. Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.)

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Each table cell will automatically enlarge as you type!

Rec'd 2/5/01 wpl

CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name): TRUMPETER SWAN		(Scientific Name) <i>Cygnus buccinator</i>
Date(s) of occurrence: 5 February 2000		
Number of birds seen: Two	Sex: Unknown	Plumage: Adult
Exact Location: Buckingham Lake		
County: Larimer County	Nearest town: Loveland	Elevation: 5085 msl
Length of observation: Roughly 20 minutes	Time(s) of observation: Approximately 2:00 PM MST	
Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Joanne Stewart		
Other Observers who independently saw the bird(s):		
Light Conditions (quality; direction relative to bird(s); position: Overcast		
Optical equipment used: 8x40 Binoculars, 32x Spotting Scope		
Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): Roughly 70 yards		
Was bird(s) photographed? Yes	If so, have you submitted photos? Yes	
Who took the photographs? Larry Semo		
Describe the general and specific habitat in which the bird(s) occurred: Partially open water of lake with ice-covered fringe		
Describe the bird's behavior (flying, feeding, habits, behaviors used in identifying the Species or in supporting the identification): Standing on edge of ice, occasionally preening.		
Describe the bird in detail. This is the most important part of this report. Include the overall size and shape and how you placed the bird in the general group that you did. Give complete details of plumage, including head, throat, undersides, nape, back, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird(s). Describe other important details, such as color and shape of bill, legs, eye, (etc.) that were important in making the identification. (Fill out this portion even if photographs are submitted; you may attach additional sheets, drawings, field sketches or copy field notes):		
Arriving at Buckingham Lake, I immediately noticed the presence of two adult swans standing on the iced edge of the lake. The following reflect identification points in the field. Overall Size, Shape, and Color: Noticeably very large in size, standing approximately 4 feet in height, with a very long neck, short legs, and colored entirely white except for the black bill and eye. Head: Large-headed with relatively flat-topped crown. Eyes black. Bill: The bill was large, long, straight, and sloped, almost Canvasback-like. The angle of the culmen was roughly a straight line to the tip of the bill. The black facial skin along the bill came to the eye and was very wide at that point, creating a look (from a distance) that the eye and bill were connected; the eye looked to be simply an elongation of the bill. From the side, the angle of the bill from the eye to the chin was diagonal (or partially concave) toward the bill. This diagonal/concave bill angle is diagnostic for Trumpeter but can be deceiving at distances. When turned toward the observer, the shape of the upper bill was a deep "V" shaped. Bill color all black except for an obvious salmon-colored upper edge to the lower mandible; no yellow lores were present. Neck: Very thick, long, and straight. In most postures, it appeared that the head was attached to the side of the neck, rather than on top (as in Tundra).		
Describe bird's call or song: None heard		

Discuss similar species and how you eliminated them:

Tundra Swan: Separation between Trumpeter and Tundra Swans can be tricky, especially at a distance. Elimination of Tundra Swan was based upon many factors. Tundra Swan bills tend to be smaller than Trumpeter Swans. The culmen profile of a Tundra will be slightly concave or dished-shape rather than the straight profile of a Trumpeter. Also from the side, the eye appears to be slightly disjunct from the bill being only joined by a small loreal area. The bill angle between the eye and the chin on a Tundra is more at a right-angle whereas the black from the anterior portion of the eye extends toward the bill and then drops ventrally to the chin in quite a straight line. This is partially explained by the reduced amount of black in the loreal region of a Tundra. When turned toward the observer, the shape of the bill-face junction of a Tundra will look like a shallow "U" instead of the deep "V" shape of a Trumpeter. Unless viewed under very close ranges, salmon-colored edges to the lower mandible of a Tundra will be almost nonexistent. Most Tundra Swans also will have a yellow loreal spot that is never found on Trumpeters (some Tundra's may not display this trait, however). The neck of a Tundra Swan is usually thinner and shorter than a Trumpeter and slightly curved on the anterior end instead of the very straight posture of a Trumpeter. This field point is extremely variable, however, due to posture.

Mute Swan: Mute Swans are as robust and thick as Trumpeter but differ by having a bright orange bill with bulbous basal knob. The neck of a Mute is typically well-curved into an almost "S" shape. The rump and tail of a Mute Swan are also usually lifted high in the air unlike Trumpeter Swan in which the tail and rump lie substantially lower than the back and wings of the bird.

Whooper Swan: With the increased spread of feral Whooper Swans in eastern North America, a brief discussion on separation between this species and Trumpeter is warranted as well. Separation between Trumpeter and Whooper is fairly straightforward. Though very similar in overall shape and appearance to Trumpeter Swan, the bill of a Whooper will be mostly yellow instead of black due to a very large yellow lore and bill patch that extends from the eyes to the nostrils and ventrally to the chin.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Have observed numerous other Trumpeter's in Wyoming, Minnesota, and Wisconsin.

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): None

This report is from notes made during XX or after observation or later from memory

Date of written report: 07/03/00

Reporting observer: Larry Semo

Signature:



Reporting Observer's Address: 9054 Dover Street

City: Westminster

State: Colorado

Zip: 80021

Send report to:
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c/o Bill Lisowsky
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Trumpeter Swan

Larry Sero

#2000-21